Amid ‘bustle and confusion’ General Nott finally marched out of Kandahar for the last time, with his 6,000 troops, on 8 August.[46]

Behind him he left the city under the charge of Shah Shuja’s youngest son, Prince Safdarjang. The handsome young prince, said to be the son of a Ludhiana dancing girl, had sworn to hold the city for the Sadozais, though Nott doubted whether the Prince would last long after his departure and privately believed ‘great confusion and bloodshed will follow our retirement’.[47] The young Prince was nonetheless determined to try to hold out if he could. ‘We should know no other feeling than a bold determination to avenge the King’s blood,’ Safdarjang wrote to Nott, soon after he had left. ‘At present my own blood is in such ferment that I can think of nothing else but the best means to obtain this vengeance. I swear to God that while life is in my body I will attend to no other matter than this: I will either share my father’s fate, or I will avenge his death.’

Eleven days later, Pollock marched out of Jalalabad with a slightly larger army of 8,000 troops. His was a much more harrowing passage. The further the Army of Retribution went, the more corpses they passed and the more macabre their journey became. First they saw ‘the sixty skeletons scattered on the hill’ of Gandamak, ‘the officers plainly distinguishable by the long hair which still remained attached to their skulls’. By the time the army came to Jagdalak ‘the pass was choked with corpses, and they had to be removed before our guns could pass’, wrote Thomas Seaton. ‘It was a terrible sight, and we felt it the more deeply from the thought that we could not sufficiently avenge such a disaster . . . All along the road, in every ravine and nook, bodies and skeletons of the Kabul fugitives were found lying as they had been cut down, or had sunk from fatigue and had perished in the intense cold.’[48] ‘Some were mere skeletons,’ noted Lieutenant Greenwood,

> while others were in better preservation. Their features were perfect, although discoloured. Their eyes had evidently been picked out by birds of prey, which wheeling in endless gyrations above my head seemed to consider me an intruder in their domain. On turning the corner of a large rock, where five or six bodies were lying in a heap together, a vulture which had been banqueting on them, hopped carelessly away to a little distance, lazily flapping its huge wings, but too indolent to fly. I turned away from the sickening sight with a sad heart, but with a stern determination to lend my best efforts to paying the Affghans the debt of revenge we owed them.[49]